▼ MALVINDER SINGH KANG, *45*

| AAP | *Anandpur Sahib, Punjab*

In the past two years of CM Bhagwant Mann, Kang has emerged as AAP's voice in Punjab, defending party and government during challenging times. Nothing askew about that, except people forget how not too long ago he was seen as a protégé of BJP leader Anurag Thakur. The Gwalior boy, who made a name in Panjab University politics, spent a decade in the BJP before joining AAP during the 2020-21 farm protests.



▼ UMMEDA RAM BENIWAL, *47*

| CONGRESS | *Barmer, Rajasthan*

All the media attention was being lavished on the young and swashbuckling Rajput leader Ravindra Singh Bhatti, fighting his Independent fight. But as the old desert saying goes, those who lose Baytu often win Barmer. Beniwal lost Baytu by only 910 votes in the 2023 assembly poll, contesting on a Rashtriya Loktantrik Party ticket. His nemesis—Harish Chaudhary of the Congress, who'd defeated him in 2018 too—turned into a benefactor, convincing him to join the GOP despite the RLP being part of the INDIA bloc. Beniwal, who supplements farm income with projects, passed the triangular test with flying colours. Bhatti came second, Union minister Kailash Chaudhary third.



▼ PRAVEEN PATEL, *45*

| BJP | *Phulpur, UP*

His dad was a Congressman, quite the norm in what was then known as "Nehru's constituency". But son learnt swimming with the BSP, so picked up enough skills to reach saffron shores—he proved his winnability for both at the assembly level. He's scaled that up to a higher level, even if only in a "thrilling finish" with 4,332 extra votes.



▼ RAJ KUMAR CHABBEWAL, *55*

| AAP | *Hoshiarpur (SC), Punjab*

Just before the polls, the two-time Congress MLA and the second-in-command in the party legislative team switched to AAP. Chabbewal, who began his political career with the BJP, joined the Congress in 2009. After an unsuccessful bid in the 2012 assembly poll, he won the next two elections. Chabbewal's former Congress colleagues claim he faced vigilance pressures following allegations of distributing fake sanction letters to SC beneficiaries of the Punjab Nirman Programme ahead of the 2022 assembly polls.



RAKESH RATHOR, *60*

| CONGRESS | *Sitapur, UP*

An OBC leader and former BJP MLA from Sitapur, Rathor joined the Congress only last year. In May 2021, several purported audio clips were leaked in which he criticised the Yogi Adityanath government.



KRISHNA DEVI PATEL, *53*

| SP | *Banda, UP*

Krishna Devi joined the Samajwadi Party last year, along with her husband, former minister Shiv Shanker Patel, following his suspension from the BJP.



ABHAY KUMAR SINHA, *52*

| RJD | *Aurangabad, Bihar*

The ex-JD(U) MLA switched to the RJD only in March. The Kushwaha leader, who defeated sitting BJP MP Sushil Kumar Singh, also influenced his community voters across Bihar.



NEERAJ MAURYA, *54*

| SP | *Aonla, UP*

The former two-term BSP MLA from Jalalabad, who served from 2007 to 2017, briefly joined the BJP before switching to the Samajwadi Party in 2022.



-Amarnath K. Menon, Prashant Srivastava, Anilesh S. Mahajan, Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Rohit Parihar, Rahul Noronha, Amitabh Srivastava and Arkamoy Datta Majumdar